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U.S.

Vermont's Most Bizarre Real-Estate Listing Is a Free College Campus

A local college closed seven years ago. It has proved hard to repurpose.

By Owen Tucker-Smith

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Green Mountain College in Poultney, Vt., in May 2019. CALEB KENNA FOR WSJ

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A year after Green Mountain College closed for good in 2019, the school found an unlikely buyer for its stately campus in rural Vermont.

Raj Bhakta was a former contestant on “The Apprentice,” an unsuccessful congressional candidate and an embattled whiskey entrepreneur. But he had some big ideas for the property—his plan would include 93 hotel rooms, 18 condos, a micro-distillery, restaurant and spa. He spent less than \$5 million for the whole campus.

Six years later, it remains mostly empty, aside from a small elementary school founded by Bhakta’s wife, with the bigger development plans called off. He is now trying to give away the land and 16 buildings.

“If you ever want to feel like you’re going nuts,” the 50-year-old said in an interview, “buy a college campus in the middle of nowhere.”

Bhakta is combing through proposals from entities that promise to maintain the roughly 115 acres. He says he is looking for applicants who can show “an alignment with the vision of the revival of the United States, Western civilization and

Christendom through faith-based education.”

The recipient should also budget \$1.5 million a year to maintain existing infrastructure and catch up on deferred maintenance, according to Bhakta’s website.



Raj Bhakta BHAKTA SPIRITS

The Green Mountain saga has taken an unusual turn, but reflects a more common challenge set off by the shrinking enrollment and financial woes closing colleges nationwide. What happens to the quads and buildings when students leave for good?

Sometimes closed schools are absorbed by a bigger college, but abrupt shutdowns can leave behind land and buildings that aren’t easily repurposed, especially in remote areas.

There are signs of life on some vacant campuses, even after long waits. A developer recently filed paperwork to turn Southern Vermont College—closed in 2019—into a luxury resort. Construction on housing is expected to start in earnest next year on the campus of Vermont’s Goddard College, which closed in 2024. Many other campuses sit idle.

In Vermont, Green Mountain’s campus anchors the end of Main Street in Poultney, a town of about 3,000 people nestled in a historic slate-mining region along the New York state border.

Bhakta had a part-time home in Vermont, 30 miles from Poultney, when Green Mountain closed. He had recently left the whiskey brand WhistlePig on bad terms after a legal battle with partners that spilled into court and ended in a confidential settlement.

He said U.S. colleges leave students “brainwashed with communist and wokeist ideology,” and that he wanted to fill the void in Poultney with a resort that could teach young Americans the craft of “first-class” liquor. The core of Bhakta’s ethos: Young Americans’ drift away from alcohol is damaging society.

“When people are alone, high on gummies and shrooms in front of their computer, they feel desperate,” he said. “This could be solved in part by going to the local pub and having a beer.”

So he brought his family and his spirits business to Poultney. In August 2020, sitting in a campus building with his 5-year-old daughter on his lap, Bhakta won an auction to buy the campus for a 77% discount to its appraised value of \$20 million just a few years earlier.

Poultney residents, hurt by the loss of a major economic engine, were eager for quick redevelopment. Bhakta solicited ideas from locals about what to do with the property and hosted neighborhood barbecues on campus.



Main Street in Poultney, Vt., in May 2019. CALEB KENNA FOR WSJ

His vision, outlined in documents filed to the town and state, included the hotel rooms, condos, micro-distillery and 200-seat restaurant. He also planned a spa and a 10-seat home theater. The college library would be used for spirits storage and a tasting room. His family would move into a historic campus building.

“If you have a vision and you can execute it, awesome,” said Devon Fowler, a Poultney native who lives across the street from Bhakta’s home, regarding his optimism at the time. “That puts prosperity in our town.”

James Johnson, owner of a local bike shop, believes 90% of the town wanted to support Bhakta. “People who don’t have a lot of means often search for a hero figure,” he said. The town’s Development Review Board approved Bhakta’s plans in early 2023.

But Bhakta still needed an environmental and community-impact approval from the state’s Land Use Review Board. He filed an application in early 2024, and the board labeled it as incomplete. After he tried again, the regulator in April 2025 still had questions.

Who is the proposed 10-seat home theater for, they asked, according to public documents from the agency. Are you still storing your vintage-car collection on site? What are you keeping at the library besides spirits? Do you have horses? Will the distillery smell?

Bhakta withdrew his application last September, according to the state records.

“Vermont’s red tape antidevelopment regime killed the project,” he said. “How do you clarify or explain the purpose of a ‘home theater?’ ” He asked. “It is where people watch things on a screen.”

State regulators notified Bhakta this year of alleged violations related to the campus, according to documents provided by the state agency. They listed issues like renovations to his home, which is on the state’s Register of Historic Places, storage of spirits on campus and running a private school there without state approval, the documents show. The notice of alleged violations was previously reported by local news outlet Seven Days.

Bhakta defended the on-campus school, repairs to the home and his spirits business. A Bhakta business partner has asked the state about a possible deal to address any violations, according to an email exchange viewed by The Wall Street Journal.

Bhakta didn't complete his application with the Vermont agency. But of the roughly 380 permit applications processed last year, none was denied, according to Peter Gill, executive director of the Land Use Review Board.



Students on campus at Green Mountain College in May 2019. CALEB KENNA FOR WSJ

There was some friction in town. Locals accustomed to using some campus facilities complained they lost access to spaces Bhakta used for his vintage cars and spirits collection. Bhakta noted he has frequently opened the college to public events. “If all the swimming pools and private places of business in Poultney were to be considered a public commons, just imagine the crippling cost of the liability insurance,” he said.

“I eventually just got to the point where I didn’t think he was going to do anything,” said Fowler, who accused Bhakta’s German shepherd of killing his chickens. The campus owner denied the charge, blaming feral cats, and called it a shakedown attempt.

In one recent July 4 parade Bhakta was driving what he said was one of Franklin D. Roosevelt’s 1933 Lincolns when it ran out of gas. Helpers had to push it. It felt like a metaphor to Johnson, the local bike-shop owner. “It was an encapsulation of his whole

program,” he said.

Now the town is waiting for a new owner to emerge. Bhakta’s request yielded more than 50 applications in the first five weeks, and late proposals have continued to trickle in. He has narrowed the field to 10 contenders, but said it isn’t clear that the right caretaker has appeared.

“We were hopeful with Raj,” said Jaime Lee, a town planning-commission member. “And now it’s hard to have faith that any one entity can maintain that entire campus.”

Owen Tucker-Smith is a news associate at The Wall Street Journal in New York. He joined the Journal as a summer 2024 intern in Washington, where he wrote about Congress and the 2024 election. Owen recently graduated from Yale University, where he earned a bachelor’s degree in statistics and data science and was a Yale Journalism...

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